

HNG VIRTUAL ASSISTANT TRACK · 2026

Lessons in Leadership

What I Learned From Mentor
Peace Umuteme - Ms. Fegs

Favour Obi

HNG Virtual Assistant Track



The Mentor Who Had Already Walked the Path.

HNG Finalist

Before becoming a mentor, she had completed all 10 stages of HNG herself and earned Finalist status. Every piece of advice came from lived experience.

Multi-Role Operator

She was supporting founders, mentoring interns, and somehow still showing up everywhere she needed to be.

Observed Up Close

I got to observe her leadership through feedback sessions, Slack conversations, and a career conversation she personally took time to have with me.

"How Is One Person Doing All of This?"

Before sending my mentor pitch, I did what every good VA does, I researched.

The more I looked through Peace's profile, the more impressed I became. She was organised, disciplined, and incredibly intentional about how she worked.

What surprised me most was her balance. One minute she was reminding me to improve a deliverable. The next, she was asking if I had eaten or telling me not to stay up too late.

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**High standards and kindness
can exist in the same person.**

— The Lesson

She Didn't Give the Answer, She Gave the Method.



Guided Through Challenge

"I want to see how resourceful you can be. Use Claude, GPT, YouTube. Figure it out. Send me the finished work by 9am." She gave the method, not the shortcut.



Clear Communication

Short, direct messages with exactly what was needed.



Accountability

She held interns to a standard she was already holding herself to and created a spreadsheet to track scores across all stages. She followed up. She noticed.

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**I'm so happy
you're here.**

One night, well past midnight, Ms. Fegs. received an urgent client request. The instructions weren't perfect, the deadline was tight. I was already tired.

She reviewed the instructions with me, said she would get some sleep, and trusted me to figure it out. By 1:54am, I had completed the presentation.

"I trust your judgment."

She sent it directly to the client.

-Ms. Fegs, after reviewing my work

The Lesson

Trust isn't built when everything is easy. It's built when someone can hand you something important, go to sleep, and know it will be handled.

How She Communicates.

Clarity

Every message had a clear purpose. Feedback came with the reason behind it. She never sent a long paragraph when one sentence would do.

Responsiveness

Available even at unconventional hours. Being responsive doesn't mean being always on, it means being reliable when it matters.

Tone

Direct but never harsh. "You didn't quite get it. But you're getting there." Honest and encouraging at the same time.

Feedback Style

She named what went wrong, explained why it mattered, and pointed toward the fix. "Here is what I expected. Here is what I got. Here is how to close the gap."

What VAs can learn: Say what you mean. Be direct without being unkind. Feedback is a service, not a punishment.

She Never Asked for Effort She Wasn't Already Giving.

Lead by Example

Supporting executives, managing tasks. She never asked for effort she was not already giving herself.

High Standards

"Your evidence folder — you could have done better." She did not lower the bar to make things comfortable. She believed it was reachable and held it there.

Ownership Culture

"I'd expect you to be proactive and not wait to be told what to do." She didn't want an assistant who waited. She wanted an operator who anticipated.

Problem Solving

When I struggled with a tool she gave me resources, a deadline, and said "Figure it out." Finding solutions independently is the skill under all other skills.

Five Things Worth Carrying Into Every Role.

01

Proactiveness is the baseline

Don't wait to be assigned. Watch for what is needed and move before you are asked.

02

Own your deliverables

Your submission is a communication piece. Make the reasoning behind your work as clear as the work itself.

03

Build systems, not shortcuts

The way you organise your work is as important as the work itself.

04

Accept feedback professionally

Listen, adjust, and deliver better. That is what she modelled and what she expected.

05

Consistency is the real skill

Showing up every stage, every submission — that consistency is what makes someone trustworthy, not just talented.

The Moments That Stick.

The Clarity call.

Had a career call with Ms. Fegs and the words she said to me that day changed my perspective about being a VA and I'm in stage 9 because of those words she said to me in stage 2.

The Notion Challenge

No step-by-step guide. Just "Figure it out and send it by 9am." I didn't like notion at first because I always saw it as been difficult but after that day, I now prefer notion.

"Please hope you have eaten?"

I was helping manage her schedule while she was checking if I had eaten. The care went both ways. Ms. Fegs is just so nice.

The Spreadsheet

Mentor Fegs created a tracker to monitor my progress across every stage. She cared enough to keep track. With that all I could do was to just try to do better in each stage.

"My irreplaceable VA."

A message I'll probably remember long after the internship ends.

BEFORE

I focused on completing tasks.

If something wasn't assigned, I probably wasn't thinking about it.

I waited for instructions.

I concentrated on getting things done.

NOW

I check in before being asked.

I look for gaps before they become problems.

I communicate my thought process, not just finished work.

I stopped seeing myself as someone who completes tasks and started seeing myself as someone who helps make operations work.

Three Lessons Worth Keeping.

01

Proactiveness is Professionalism

Waiting to be told is not neutral. In executive support, anticipation is the job. Mentor Fegs modelled this every day and expected the same from the people she mentored.

02

Systems Create Reliability

Task trackers, VA spreadsheets, Notion workspaces, feedback patterns. The way you organise your work is what makes you trustworthy at scale.

03

Feedback Accelerates Growth

Every correction she gave me was a shortcut to a better version of my work.



Thank You, Ms. Fegs.

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Thank you for your guidance, your honesty, and your genuine investment in my growth throughout this internship.

You held a high bar and still made me feel like I could reach it. That combination is rare, and I do not take it for granted.

Because of you, I leave this internship not just with skills, but with a standard I am holding myself to for every executive I will ever support.